

The Sleeping Garden

The Floating Isles are islands adrift in a calm sky, in a realm where magic only ever helps: it grows, it heals, it changes one thing into another, and it lets you speak with animals and objects. It never harms. On the home island, the House of the Little Mages sits at the highest point, where young mages learn their first spells, and the city where the families live spreads below. Inside the school grounds lies the Great Garden, the green heart of the whole island. Here nobody loses; you find your way by being kind and full of ideas.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.

★ *The same adventure as the simple telling, with a little more room to breathe. Read it aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. The beats and the puzzles are identical; only the language has grown up.*

Before you begin

This morning you wake to a silence so complete that it feels like a held breath. From the high window of the House of the Little Mages you look down over the home island, and your stomach tightens. The Great Garden, the green heart of the whole island, has turned grey and motionless, as though something has coaxed it into a deep sleep. The flowers are shut tight. The fountain, which usually murmurs all day, makes no sound at all.

You are two young mages, and this is your first real adventure. You shoulder your bag, glance at each other, and without quite planning to, you say the same words at the same moment: "Let us go and wake it up." Below you, the golden path winds away into the quiet.

★ *Choose your mage name and your magic, Light, Grow, Change, or Voice, before you take the first step.*

Stop 1 The Vine Gate

The path brings you to a tall gate, and your way is blocked. Over the seasons the vines have grown across it and pulled themselves into an enormous, stubborn knot of leaves, and the gate will not give so much as an inch.

Something stirs in the haze beside the path. A cat the colour of fog pads out and sits, curling its tail neatly around its paws. It is the Mist Cat, and everyone on the island knows it turns up exactly when a hint might be useful. It studies the knot, then turns its calm eyes to you, as if to say: well, what shall we do about this?

★ *How do you open the way? You might coax a gap to grow, change the knot into something looser, or simply ask the vines, politely, to step aside. See what you can invent.*

The moment the gate swings wide, a single sleepy flower unfurls one petal, as if testing whether morning has truly come. The garden is waking, just a little.

Stop 2 The Flower Bed

Beyond the gate lies a wide flower bed, and here something has gone gently wrong. Four flowers have drooped and forgotten where they belong, their colours muddled. As you draw near, a thread of a voice hums an old planting rhyme, the kind a gardener might teach a child: "First the sun, then the sea, then the berry, then fly free."

The flowers clearly want to stand in their proper order again. They have simply forgotten which colour comes where, and they are hoping you can work it out.

★ *Each line of the rhyme is a clue to a colour. Which flower is the sun, which is the sea? Set the four of them in the order the rhyme sings, and see what happens.*

As the last flower slips into place, all four lift their heads and open wide, turning their faces up to a sky that is slowly bluing. Two more corners of the garden shake off their grey.

Stop 3 The Talking Fountain

The path opens onto a wide stone fountain, and the first thing you notice is the silence. No splash, no trickle, not even a drip. The water lies flat and grey as an old coin, and somehow the whole fountain seems to droop, as if it has forgotten how to be glad. When you lean in to listen, it lets out a long, low sigh. It is not broken. It is only waiting for a reason to sing again.

★ *How do you coax it back? A song, a joke, a few kind words? The fountain does not need fixing so much as cheering. What will you try?*

At the first sign of real cheer the water leaps upward, catches the light, and breaks into a bright, splashing tune it had clearly been longing to sing. Now only the very heart of the garden remains asleep.

The Heart of the Garden

At the centre of the Great Garden, where the golden path finally ends, you find the cause of all of it: a small sprite, curled up as tight as a fist, with a face full of worry. This is the one who sent the garden to sleep. Not out of malice, you realise, and not as any kind of villain. It was simply lonely, so lonely that it did not know how to ask for company, and a sleeping garden was the only way it knew to keep anyone near.

There is nothing here to defeat. There never was.

★ *What do you say to the sprite? How might you show it, in words or in a gesture, that it does not have to be alone any more?*

When you offer your friendship, plainly and kindly, the sprite's worried face softens into the first smile it has worn in a very long time. And all at once the Great Garden wakes around you: petals spring open, the fountain sings, the Mist Cat stretches in a patch of new sunlight, and warmth pours back across the whole island.

You solved it the way every adventure on the Isles is solved, together, with kindness and with your own ideas. Well done, both of you.

The Sleeping Garden: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which on the Isles means a few small jobs at once: narrator, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure (a building-brick minifigure works well) on the Start.
- Each player chooses one magic: Light, Grow, Change, or Voice. Two different magics work best, because combining them is half the fun.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). These are spent and refilled during play.
- Build the objects that come up (a key, a flower, a bridge) from household bits and bricks as you go. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Instead each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge in this story can be played with a single ordinary die, and richer dice sets simply make it feel grander.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to try the same idea again, or
- **Combine two magics** once per stop to pass the challenge with no roll at all (Light and Voice, say, or Grow and Change, working as one).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. So nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed.

Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. The lesson underneath the whole game is that you get further together.

The surprise

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a surprise and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for surprises; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Surprise
1	A Messenger Butterfly flutters past and gives you one free hint.

2	You find a glimmer of energy: take back one energy star.
3	A kindly breeze: the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Mist Cat appears and purrs. All is well; carry on.
5	A wise creature lets you repeat one roll later, whenever you like.
6	A little song drifts by and everyone dances for one happy turn.

How it ends

The Heart of the Garden is not a battle. The "antagonist" is the Lonely Sprite, who sent the garden to sleep only because it wanted a friend. The adventure is won when the children offer it friendship. Let that land gently; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for how to play the heart, and for the solutions to the three stops.

The Sleeping Garden: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward good ideas and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Vine Gate (Easy)

The challenge. The gate is tied shut by a thick knot of vines and will not open on its own.

Intended solutions. Any of the magics can solve this:

- **Grow** a gap in the vines, or grow a vine staircase over the gate.
- **Change** the knot into something looser, or into a key for the latch.
- **Voice:** ask the vines politely to unwind and step aside.
- **Light** can reveal a hidden catch that, once seen, is easy to undo.

Fallback. If a roll misses, the Mist Cat nudges a loose vine to show where to start, then the players spend an energy star or combine two magics to finish. Nobody waits at this gate for long.

Stop 2: The Flower Bed (Normal)

The challenge. Four flowers have lost their order. A small voice hums the clue: "First the sun, then the sea, then the berry, then fly free." The players must set the four flowers in the right colours.

Solution. Each line is a colour:

- "the sun" = **yellow**
- "the sea" = **blue**
- "the berry" = **red**
- "fly free" (off into the clouds) = **white**

So the order is **yellow, blue, red, white**. Build or place four flowers in that order. Logic and a little vocabulary do the work here, not a magic.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, read the rhyme again slowly, one line at a time, and let them place one flower per line. Getting there with help still counts as a full success, and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Talking Fountain (Normal)

The challenge. The fountain has gone quiet and sad and will not flow. It does not need fixing; it needs cheering.

Intended solution. This is a **Voice** moment. The players speak to the fountain and lift its mood: sing it a song, tell it a joke, or offer a few kind words. Any genuine attempt to cheer it should work. Light (a warm glow) or a combined magic is a fine alternative.

Fallback. If the children freeze, have the fountain ask a tiny question of its own ("Do you know any songs about water?") to give them a thread to pull. The moment they try, let the water leap and sing.

The Heart of the Garden (no roll)

This is the resolution, not a puzzle, so there is no band and no roll. The players find the **Lonely Sprite** curled up at the centre. It sent the garden to sleep because it was lonely and did not know how to ask for a friend.

Play it softly. Let the children decide how to reach out: a kind word, an invitation to play, a promise to visit. There is no fight and no trick. When they offer friendship, the sprite smiles and the whole garden wakes at once. End on that warmth. The children have won by being kind and full of ideas, which is the only way anyone wins on the Isles.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.